



The Nakhla Stool System

Second Edition | Isola Downtown Design 2026



Studio Gerald Jason Cruz

A Modular Furniture System Rooted in Emirati Heritage.

A single unit with infinite configurations. The Nakhla Stool reimagines the date palm as a furniture system to activate social spaces.

Project Details at a glance:

Title	The Nakhla Stool
Edition	Second Edition
Designer	Gerald Jason Cruz
Produced in	Abu Dhabi, UAE

Dimensions	46 x 46 x 49.4 cm
Weight	18 kg
Materials	DesertBoard (palm-frond based OSB)



The Nakhla Stool as a seat or side table.



The Nakhla Stool as a plinth or standing table.



The Nakhla Stool as a sculptural piece.

The Date Palm as a living symbol.

Dubbed the “tree of life” by the late Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan (may his soul rest in peace), the *Nakhla* or Date Palm has had many versatile uses. It gives nourishment through its date fruit, materials through its fronds and leaves, and shade for people to gather and rest beneath it.

The Nakhla Stool celebrates this icon by fully reembodying the Date Palm in form, material, and versatility.

It was important to investigate the date palm not just as a material or a cultural symbol, but in its cultivation. At the beginning I ask this simple question:

Where does the humanity from the date palm tree come from?

The answer is that it is in the human interaction that goes into it; the way we trim and grow the tree. I aimed to reflect the process in which the date palm is maintained, used, and celebrated in the creation of this stool.

Studies of Arabic Architecture.

Repetitive, geometric patterns and cylindrical forms served as key inspiration for the furniture piece. Visiting, photographing, and studying these iconic buildings of Abu Dhabi informed the development of the design.



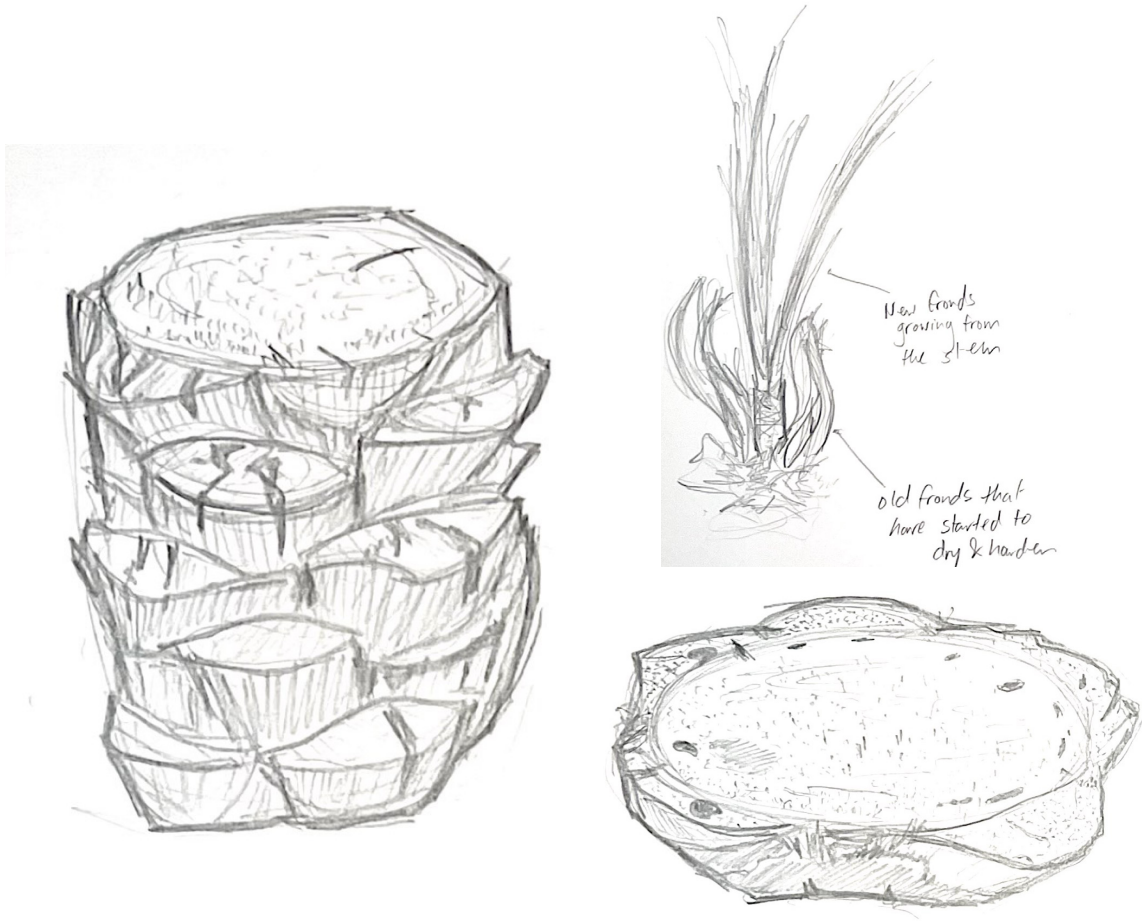
Date Palm Trunk specimens



Dates growing on the palm tree



Sheikh Zayed gathering with others underneath a Date Palm (National Archives)



Drawings of the Date Palms anatomy, form, growth



Al Bahar Towers, Abu Dhabi. Photo taken by Gerald Jason Cruz.



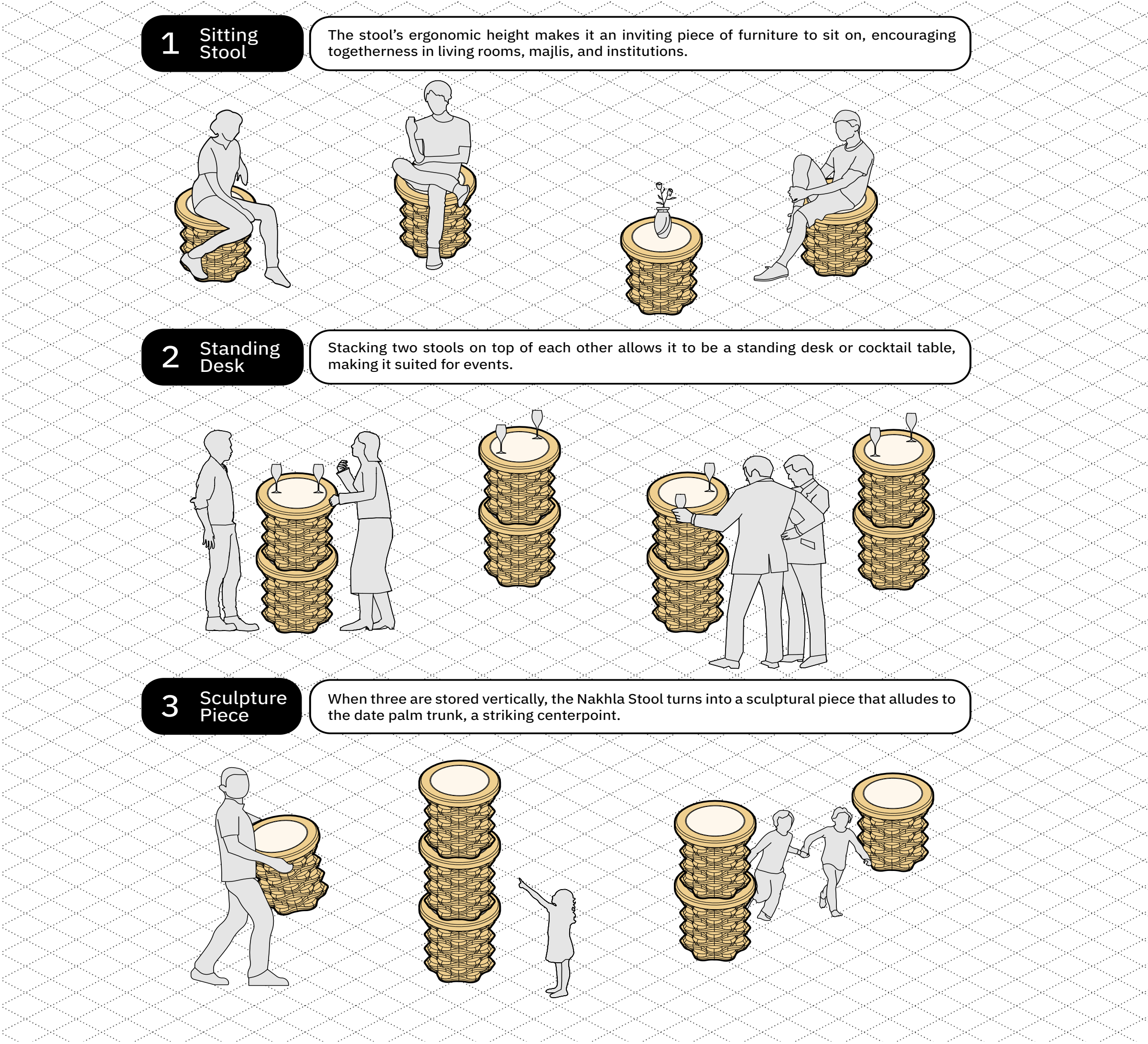
Al Ibrahimi Building, Abu Dhabi. Photo taken by Gerald Jason Cruz.

It's not just a stool...

It's a system.

A single, geometric building block that transforms across scales and uses.

The Nakhla Stool takes inspiration from the Emirati cultural icon to activate social spaces. Each set comes with three stools that are a larger part of a whole. In the same way as the date palm tree, it encourages people to gather by activating social spaces. The system stacks units vertically for different functions.



A Materiality fully of the Date Palm.

The Nakhla Stool is simple in its materiality, being made fully out of DesertBoard, a locally produced engineered wood made out of waste palm fronds.



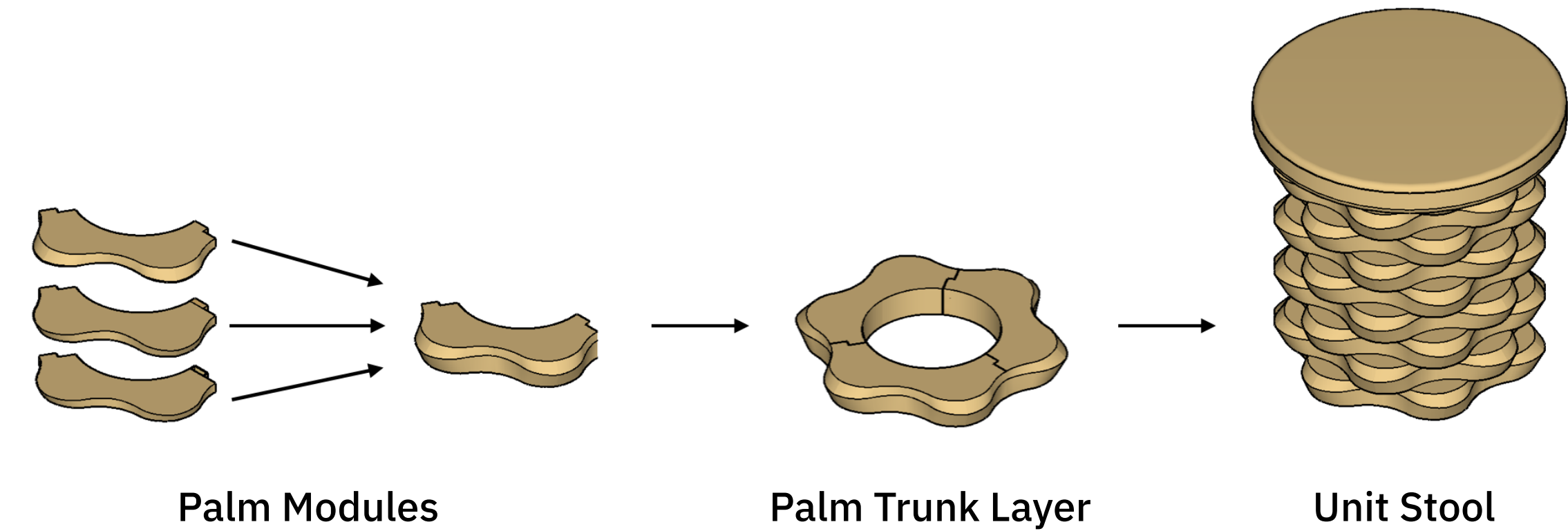
DesertBoard material surface

Process and Fabrication.

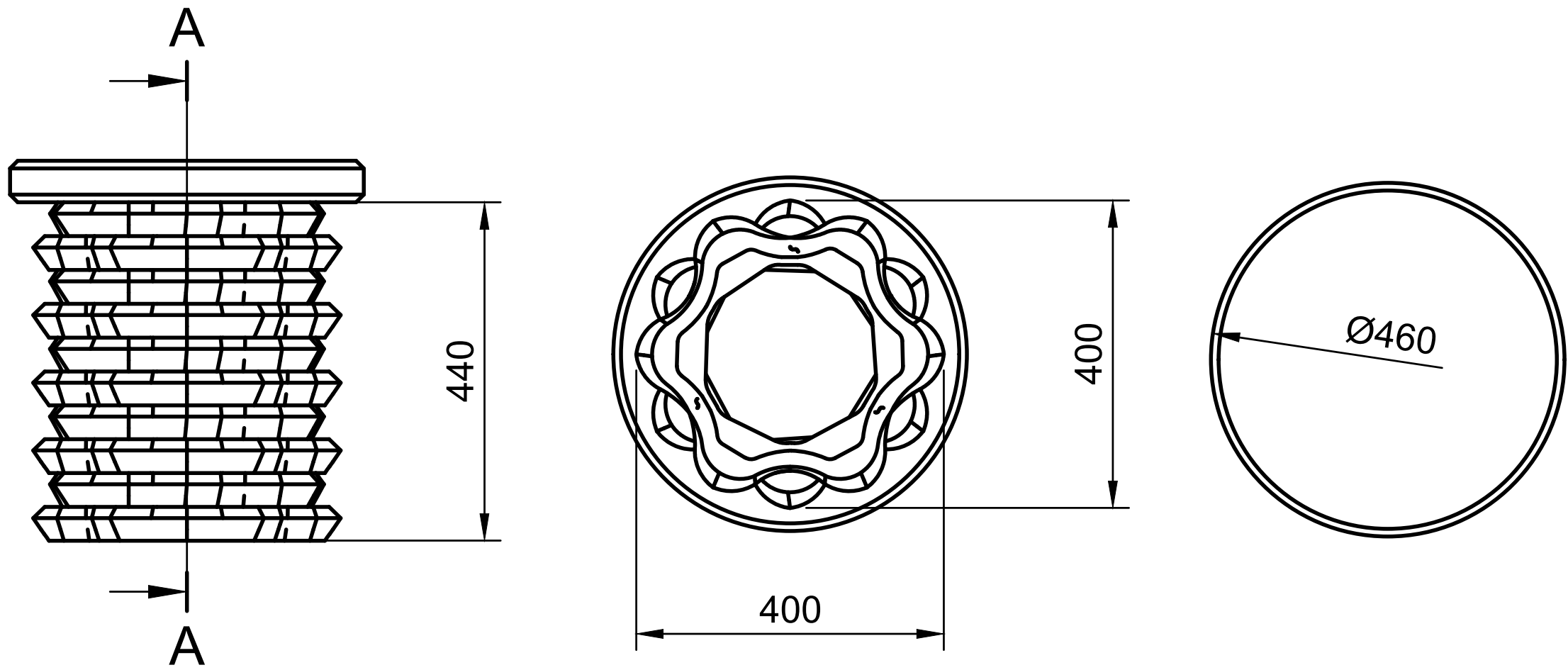
The final assembly process leverages computer aided manufacturing and a modular design to increase efficiency and decrease waste material. Standardized “Palm Modules” made of 18 mm pieces, are cut as top, middle, and bottom pieces. These modules are assembled to make a layer. 8 layers are stacked and offset by 30 degrees to form the body of the stool. When cutting, the pieces are fit like a puzzle in order maximize material usage.



CNC Routing of palm modules



The Nakhla Stool assembly process



Relevant dimensions

Thank you.